

Partition of Bengal of 1905

The Partition of Bengal was the most important event in the history of Bengal. The Partition of Bengal was announced in 7 July, 1905 by the Viceroy of India, Lord Curzon. The work for which Lord Curzon earned an immortal fame was his Partition of Bengal. In January 1905, Lord Curzon was appointed Viceroy of India.¹ Till the time of Curzon, the whole area covering Bengal, Bihar and Orissa remained under one administration. It was too big in size. The area of that province was 189,000 sq miles. Its population was nearly 78 million. Its population was nearly double the population of England.² Bengal in those days was the biggest province of India. Lord Curzon thought it unwise to keep such a huge area as one province.

In 1866, a devastating famine was appeared in Orissa. Millions of people died in that famine. Then British administration formed an inquiry team to find out the reasons behind the famine. According to the report given by the inquiry team, this Bengal province is too big in size. They have to face many administrative difficulties. Administration could not take proper steps in emergency situation due to the vastness and geographical structure of the province. In 1867 Sir William Grey and in 1872 Sir John Campbell informed the upper authority in England that it is quite impossible for a governor to rule such a vast province, Bengal. But the authority did not give any response to their report. The government announced the idea for partition in January 1904. The idea was opposed by Henry John Stedman Cotton, Chief Commissioner of Assam (1896-1902).³ Partition, most significantly, is a lesson in abject failure of understanding between two very large communities- Hindus and Muslims. Unbelievable as it may sound now, the Hindus, Muslims, Shikhs, Christians, and other communities lived side by side for hundreds of years, mostly in peace, at times in conflict, but not along the rigid communal divides that British rulers formulated to suit their “divide and rule” policy. It was started with the British desire to know the mix of the population that they were ruling. The 1871 census gave rise to an emerging sense of separate identities among the cultural, ethnic, and religious groups. This census attempted to list every Indian according to language, caste, religion, etc. As it happened, religious identities were attributed to groups when census takers were unsure because of the diverse and extremely intermingled nature of the religious practices that were being recorded. So suddenly one became a member of this or the other group or even religion, as labeled by the census official, without being personally aware of his or her transformation. But historically, religious

¹ Joya Chatterji, 'Partition Studies: Prospects and Pitfalls', 'Star Weekend, The Daily Star(August 25,2017), P:39-42

² Serajul Islam Choudhury, 'How a nationalist movement turned communal', 'Star Weekend, The Daily Star(August 25,2017), P: 5-8

³ Gerald Lerson, 'Partition: The pulsing heart that grieved', Journal of Asian Studies 73(2014):13-6

and cultural practices had overlapped and gotten entwined between groups of people and it would be quite common that one village or groups of villages took up certain religious practices of another. ⁴ On July 20th 1905, the first partition of Bengal along religious lines was approved in London by the Secretary of State of India.

The decision Partition of Bengal was announced by Lord Curzon, then Viceroy of India in July 1905. This partition came into effect in October 1905. Taking the eastern half of Bengal, namely, the Dacca, Chittagong, and Rajshahi division and uniting those with Assam, Lord Curzon Formed a new province, named as 'Eastern Bengal and Assam.' Dacca became the capital of the new province. The western half of Bengal with Bihar and Orissa remained as another province. Calcutta remain its capital. The area of the newly formed province was 106,504 sq miles and its population was 31 million and majority was Muslims. Sir Joseph Bampfylde Fuller was appointed as the Governor of this province. A managerial and a revenue board are also formed. But the Judiciary of the newly formed province was kept under the Calcutta High Court. The area of Western Bengal was 141,580 sq miles and its population was nearly 54 million and majority was Hindus. Sir Endro Frezer was appointed as the Governor of that province. ⁵

In 1905, there were administrative, political, economic and social causes behind the Partition of Bengal and following issues are discussed below:

Administrative Reason: Administrative problem was the main reason behind the Partition of Bengal. Bihar, Nagpur and Orissa were under 'Bengal Presidency' before the partition. In British period, 'Bengal Presidency' was the largest province in size and population. It was 179,000 sq miles in size and its population was about 70 million. It was too big in size and population for a governor to rule. Many governors informed upper authority in London about their administrative problems but the authority did not give any response to their report before Lord Curzon. In 1899, Lord Curzon was appointed as the governor of this subcontinent. At that time, organized Nationalist movement started against the British rule in India led by the Indian Congress. Lord Curzon realized that if he divided the vast province 'Bengal Presidency' into two parts and appoint different governor for each province, then it will be easy to control and there will be no administrative problems what were seen in previous years. Besides, backward rural people will get enough opportunity for being educated. They will also get enough chance for developing their business. Lord Curzon believed that East Bengal was neglected and as a result underdeveloped. These were the administrative reasons behind the Partition of Bengal. ⁶

⁴ Mahfuz Anam, 'Why this special issue on Partition?' Star Weekend, The Daily Star(August 25,2017), p:2-3

⁵ ডঃ আঃ রহিম, 'বাংলার মুসলমানদের ইতিহাস', পৃঃ ২০০

⁶ রাখী বর্মণ;প্রফেসর ইয়াসমিন আহমেদ, 'ব্রিটিশ ভারতে রাজনৈতিক ও সাংবিধানিক উন্নয়ন', পৃঃ ২১২

Political Reasons: The following reasons are responsible for the Partition of Bengal:

*Destroying Nationalism Thought: Since the Indian Congress was formed in 1885, the middle class Hindu people started developing their political position in Indian politics. The whole politics of Indian Sub-Continent was maintained from Bengal or Calcutta. For this reason Lord Curzon, Andro Frezer etc tried to scatter their communication. As majorities emerged with their inbuilt confidence, so did the minorities with their fears, and the British played on both, specially the latter. And as it became more and more evident that due to the changing power dynamics and rising consciousness of the Indian population there was like to be, in however limited a scale, more power sharing in the current days, identities and the numbers each group represented became vital.⁷

Isolation between Hindu-Muslim: The British rulers had succeeded so many times on the basis of 'divide and rule' policy. By dividing the Bengal again, they practiced this and made this effective. So they tried to create conflict between Hindu and Muslim community.

Muslims Demand: Nawab Sir Salimullah, the representative from East Bengal demanded this partition because he thought the East Bengal should come to the limelight. And for this, he started to create consciousness among the people of East Bengal. The following issues were pointed out by Nawab Sir Salimullah to the British authority:

- At that time, the Hindu people were majority and very much powerful. So they got the advantage in government services or other business related occupations.
- Maximum of the Hindu Zamindars collected tax from the East Bengal and invested in Calcutta. So the people of East Bengal were lagging behind.
- Before the partition of Bengal, Calcutta was the capital of Bengal. So the industries and commercial factories were built centering Calcutta. On the other hand, people of East Bengal were deprived from their rational rights. For example, Jute was produced in East Bengal, but the factories were in West Bengal.
- As Calcutta was the capital of Bengal, it was the center of politics and maximum rich Hindu people lived in Calcutta. So they did not think about the minority Muslim people of the East Bengal.⁸

As a result, Nawab Sir Salimullah thought about the Muslim and showed his logics for the partition of Bengal.

⁷ Bipan Chandra Lal, "History of Modern India", pp. 248-249

⁸ Haimanti Roy, "Partition of Contingency? Public Discourse in Bengal, 1946–1947," *Modern Asian Studies*, (November 2009)

Economic Reason: Economic reasons were also responsible for the partition of Bengal. The economy of east Bengal was agriculture related. But they did not try to improve the position of the farmers.

~ At that time, Calcutta was the center of the business in east India. Almost every raw materials were produced from east Bengal. For this reason, Calcutta was improving day by day and on the other hand, east Bengal was deprived and undeveloped. So they thought they could be able to improve their economic condition if the partition of Bengal happened and they supported it .

~ Chittagong was the center of foreign trade in Assam and east Bengal. But as Calcutta was the center of the trade, so Chittagong could not flourish. So they thought if the partition happened, they could bring the glory of Chittagong.

~ As the Zamindar lived in Calcutta , they collected the forceful revenue from the east Bengal and made their life comfortable. So the majority of east Bengal supported this partition of Bengal.

Social Reason: In British period, the Hindu were privileged, on the other hand the Muslims were tortured on many ways. So when lord Curzon proposed the partition of Bengal, the Muslim showed their support to his decision with very much humbleness. But on the other hand , the Hindus became furious. Even RabindraNath Tagore wrote his famous song “Amar Sonar Bangla” on the basis of this event.

Religious Cause: The maximum number of Hindu peoples were lived in the western part and on the other hand , the majority number of Muslim people lived in the eastern part. So on the basis of religion, the British made this plan to divide the Bengal province into two parts. It's true that British rule united India , but uniting the people of this subcontinent was never the intention of the British.⁹

Resistance: Around the partition, an organized national movement began to be formed against the British, which raised a great political storm in India, thereby resulting in a country-wide agitation. The partition not only brought the *Indian National Congress* unequivocally into politics, but it also brought the division between moderates and extremists inside Congress, into the limelight.¹⁰

Effects and Reaction of partition of Bengal of 1905: The effects of the partition of Bengal of 1905 were huge. There were opposite reactions between the Hindu and the Muslim.

⁹ Chakrabarty, “The partition of Bengal and Assam”, page 142

¹⁰ Chatterji , “Spoils of partition”, Page 244 – 245

Reactions of the Muslim community: The Muslim people of east Bengal were very much happy for the partition of Bengal because they thought they could be able to seek the attention of the British government. The Muslim of the east Bengal realized that they would be able to trade free and in a sound way. That would be blessings for the economy. They thought the zamindars will return back and give attention to the poor class. As a result the partition of Bengal was accepted by muslim community. The Muslim treated the Hindus as their antagonist and the Hindus were against the partition of Bengal. So the Muslim thought they had won against the Hindus.

Reactions of the Hindu community: When the partition of Bengal held in 1905 by lord Curzon, the neglected and lagged behind muslims were happy but the Hindus could not accept the decision taken by the British authority. The hindus thought they will not be able to flourish their progress of economy. The landlords and the capitalist society could not accept the decision.

The following reasons were most worthy for the contradiction characters of the hindu:

- ~ Business class of the Calcutta assumed that Chittagong port will make room for the east Bengal and the importance of Calcutta port will decrease.
- ~ The lawyers from Calcutta dependent on the customer from east Bengal. So they feared losing their income if a new high court establish in Dhaka, the capital of the newly formed province.
- ~ At that time maximum newspaper were published from western part and the owner of the newspaper were from west bangle. They feared if any newspaper introduce in the eastern part, they could face loss in their business.
- ~ The Hindu zamidars thought the cultivators of the east will go against the revenue system. So they were afraid of this partition of Bengal.
- ~ The politicians of the west thought that they will lose their power on the Indian politics. That's why they were against the partition of Bengal. ¹¹

The partition has also left a significant impact on the people of Bengal as well as those belonging to the Indian subcontinent. Partition triggered riots and an unavoidable and colossal wave of migration, resulting in hundreds and thousands of people moving to what they hoped would be the "safer territory".¹²

¹¹ Anjali Gera Roy (2008). *Partitioned lives : narratives of home, displacement, and resettlement*. New Delhi : Dorling Kindersley (India). pp. 66=68.

¹² Chakrabarty, Bidyut (2004). *The Partition of Bengal and Assam 1932-47*. New Delhi. p. 108.

In July 1905, when Lord Curzon decided dividing the Bengal and announced the historic Partition of Bengal in Simla, and there was a lot of reaction in Bengal. People of different levels of Bengal and newspapers started to protest against British imperialist plot. When Mr. Curzon declared his decision to declare "the decision of Partition of Bengal", Surendranath Bandyopadhyay assured him that "I will make a change of this firm decision".¹³ Lord Curzon remained firm on the decision of partition of Bengal on October 16, 1905, ignoring all the protests and criticism of the people of Bengal. As a result, the entire Bengali became the face of protest on that day. According to Rabindranath Tagore's proposal, 'Rakhi Bandhan Utsav' was celebrated on the same day as a symbol of communal harmony.¹⁴ On the advice of Ramendrasundar Trivedi, 'Arandhan' was celebrated at home in the house as a symbol of unity of Bengalis. Hats, shops, school colleges, courts are closed. Millions of people in Bengal joined the procession, protest meeting and strike. The movement against the partition of Bengal came in the form of a mass mass movement. The government followed strict harsh regimes to protest the protesters. The nationalist journalism is a vocal tone. The publication of the Jugantar's publication was stopped by the government order. The editor of 'Sandhya', the editor of Brahmbandbowdhury Upadhyay, was charged with raising anti-British attitudes. Another newspaper 'Barisal Hitiyashi' was attacked by government suppression policy. The government was a bit relieved due to the absence of corruption. At this time, on July 13, 1905, in the editorial article 'Sanjivani', edited by Krishnakumar Mitra, the first public boycott movement was called against the English government. He urged the countrymen to boycott foreign goods and take swadeshi and pressurize the British government. His boycott and Swadeshi generous response in the heart of the ideal countrymen.

The anti-British movement or Swadeshi Movement gained popularity as the anti-British movement that started in 1905 against the partition of Bengal. A swadeshi of the joint character of this movement and the other is known as boycott. 'Swadeshi' and 'Boycott' were the main arms of the anti-partition movement.

¹³ Bandyopadhyay, Sekhar (1997). *Caste, Protest and Identity in Colonial India: The Namasudras of Bengal, 1872-1947*. p. 225